S-75 Desna missiles, which were taken to their preselected locations at night. The missiles and their crews belonged to two antiaircraft divisions. Their overall command was executed by Lieutenant General Stepan Grechko, commander of the air defenses of the Moscow region. Each of the divisions under Grechko's command had three regiments, each consisting of four squadrons. Each squadron had one launching site with six launchers. Thus, between the two divisions, there were twenty-four launching sites and 144 launchers. The plan was to supply each launcher with four S-75 Desna missiles, 576 missiles altogether. According to a later CIA estimate, during the first week of August the construction of SAM sites began in locations near Matanzas, Havana, Mariel, Bahía Honda, Santa Lucia, San Julián, and La Coloma.[10]

The launch sites photographed by a U-2 plane on August 29 belonged to the eleventh antiaircraft division, formed in the Ukrainian city of Dnipropetrovsk and commanded by Major General Mikhail Tokarenko. Captain E. N. Evdokimov, deputy commander of one of the regiments of the division, later recalled: "All squadrons of the regiment took up their positions in the course of August." They "formed a defensive zone covering the western part of Cuba from the north; the duty of that group in battle was to protect the launch sites of the two R-12 missile divisions and the airfield where the IL-28 carrying nuclear weapons were based (San Julian)."[11]

The forty-three-year-old Tokarenko was a former pilot who had completed 465 missions during World War II, taken part in fifty battle encounters with enemy planes, and downed twenty of them. He was awarded the gold star medal of the Hero of the Soviet Union, the highest Soviet military decoration, in April 1945. Having assumed command of the antiaircraft division in Dnipropetrovsk in 1961, Tokarenko was eager to prove himself worthy of the appointment. It turned out that he was too eager for his own good. He would not survive in his position for even a few weeks, his crime being a cavalier attitude toward the secrecy of the mission.

On July 24, while visiting the Pinar del Río region on the western tip of Cuba to look for good locations for one of his launch sites, Tokarenko decided to reassure the Cuban officers there that the Soviet Union would not abandon their country. "Guys, don't worry, the Soviet people won't abandon Cuba in this period, when its fate is being threatened," declared